

PTI

from North Karnataka. Kharge is clear, though, that he is not in the running for the CM's post. "As Congress president, if I can appoint CMs to various states, why should I be interested in being appointed a CM?" he asks.

THE SAFFRON STRATEGY

When the BJP's top brass, including Modi, Shah and Nadda, met the core strategists to analyse the party's poll prospects in Karnataka, the feedback they got was that the perceived lack of good governance was an issue and there was anti-incumbency, particularly against many of the sitting MLAs. While Bommai was seen as "a fantastic intellectual", he was yet to emerge as a mass leader who could sway voters. The party's other worry was that while the formidable Lingayat community remained committed to it, to get a clear majority, the BJP would have to forage far beyond that 17 per cent bloc and elicit the support of other caste groups as well. The Hindutva card was mainly useful in coastal Karnataka where the Hijab and Halal controversy had erupted—the BJP is sure of bagging almost all the 19 seats there. Pushing the polarisation game to other districts was considered counter-productive. As a senior party official said, "The strategy was to consolidate the bastions we had with us while getting seats from other areas."

A key prong of the BJP strategy is what the party seniors euphemistically call 'social engineering', in other words playing the caste and reservations cards. The first move came in October 2022, nearly eight months before the polls, when the Bommai government promulgated an ordinance to increase reservation in education and employment for Scheduled Castes by 2 per cent and for Scheduled Tribes by 4 per cent. It further carved out internal reservations for Dalits by apportioning the 17 per cent SC reservation among the four groups—SC Left (6 per cent), SC Right (5.5 per cent), 'Touchables' (4.5 per cent) and Others (1 per cent). The SC Left, which comprises the most backward Madiga community, has been demanding internal reservations for very long—and by granting them that, the BJP hopes to retain their vote. However, in the process, the 'touchable' communities such as the Banjara and Bhovi feel aggrieved. Overall, though, the BJP hopes the goodwill earned by implementing this long-standing demand will enable them to win votes among both the SCs and STs who are settled mostly in Kalyana Karnataka or the districts adjoining Hyderabad.

The most contentious move, however, came just before the Election Commission of India announced the dates for the polls and the model code of conduct kicked in. The Bommai government scrapped the OBC reservations for Muslims and redistributed the 4 per cent quota thus freed up to the Veerashaiva-Lingayats and Vokkaligas, the state's two prominent communities that were demanding an increase in reservations. "We ended the special favour that was given for political gain," said Union home minister Shah, claiming the reservation for Muslims wasn't constitutionally valid. In doing so, the BJP was hoping to win more support from the two major communities even while playing its Hindutva card. But with the matter now being heard by the Supreme Court, the Karnataka government has put that order on hold.

THE RAINBOW COUNTER

The Congress accuses the BJP of snatching away the reservation given to Muslims—on the basis of their social backwardness—as a ploy to polarise communities ahead of the election. "Is there any report recommending that? Or any judgment? In the absence of all these things, isn't it divisive politics?" asks Siddaramaiah. The Congress expects the Muslim vote, which amounts to 13 per cent in the state, to consolidate completely in its favour. The party also has a rainbow coalition of castes with